

Topic 4: Biodiversity and natural resources

The topic focuses on biodiversity and the wealth of natural resources used by humans. The meaning of biodiversity and how it can be measured is considered first and how all this diversity has come about through adaptation and natural selection. It has sections on both traditional and novel uses of plants and plant fibres and the use of chemical extracts from animals and plants. The concern for disappearing biodiversity and loss of potential natural resources is used to highlight the need for biologists to identify, name and classify species. The topic finishes by looking at the role of zoos in conservation of endangered species. General biological principles covered include the relationship of plant anatomy to function and the structure and role of cellulose and starch.

6.2 Assessment information

This unit is assessed by means of a written examination paper, which carries 80 marks, lasts 1 hour 30 minutes and will include:

- objective questions
- structured questions
- short-answer questions

and will also cover:

- *How Science Works*
- practical-related questions.

Students may use a calculator.

The quality of written communication will be assessed in the context of this unit through questions which are labelled with an asterisk (*). Students should take particular care with spelling, punctuation and grammar, as well as the clarity of expression, on these questions.